

The General's Mountain: Hirafu, Kutchan and the Making of a Ski Town

A volcanic cone the Ainu and later the Wajin both named after old legends, a homestead cut from raw forest in 1892, and a station that has sent skiers up the same mountain trail since the 1920s: this dossier follows Kutchan's Hirafu district, and its neighbor the renamed town of Niseko, from settlement to the powder-snow resort of today.



ニセコひらふ・倶知安

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (7 chapters, about 1800 words)
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

Two Names for One Cone

This ground is young volcanic country. The regional survey used elsewhere in this series classes almost the whole study area as either old volcanic apron or volcanic foot-slope, built up from the eruptions of the near-symmetrical cone that rises to the south-east. A 1924 ski guidebook published by the Railway Ministry already called that cone by the nickname still used today, Ezo-Fuji, "for its trim, elegant, truncated-cone shape" — and by its Ainu-derived name, Makkari-nupuri. A widely repeated local tradition ties the mountain's more formal name to something older still: the eighth-century chronicle *Nihon Shoki* records the general Abe no Hirafu leading a fleet of some 180 ships on a campaign in 658 CE that reportedly set up an administrative base called "Koho Yotei." Wajin settlers matched that ancient name to this mountain and wrote it with the same characters, 後方羊蜚 — read in one tradition as Shiribeshi-yama, in the other, using the same characters' Chinese-derived sound, as Yotei-zan.¹⁸

The same legend gave a neighboring settlement its name. Hirafu, a district of Kutchan today served by its own station, is said locally to preserve Abe no Hirafu's own name, and a Hirafu Shrine was built in 1912 to mark the tradition — though local historians themselves note that which of several rival towns, if any, the general's forces actually reached remains an open question; Yoichi, to the north, makes the same claim. Kutchan's own name has a separate, Ainu origin, usually explained as a place where water runs out through a narrow gorge; the characters 倶知安 were chosen for it in 1893 by a Hokkaido government official, Shirani Takeshi, the same year the settlement was registered as a village.²³⁸

A Homestead in the Wilderness

Kutchan's own account of its founding puts the date precisely: on 19 May 1892, the first settlers entered the Kutchan wilderness and began felling the oak and Japanese cottonwood forest tree by tree. The town's own year-by-year record names Manabe Hamasaburo as leading that first party of six; a later town retrospective instead credits the drive to Niki Takekichi, a settler from Tokushima Prefecture remembered locally as "the father of Kutchan's pioneering." The village was formally established the following year, 1893; a branch office of neighboring Abuta village's administration opened in Kutchan in 1895, and in 1896 — while the settlement was still, by its own telling, enduring a harsh pioneering existence — its first school, Kutchan Jinjo Elementary, opened its doors.²⁵

Growth followed the railway. When the Hokkaido Railway (today's JR Hakodate Main Line) reached the district on 15 October 1904, Kutchan and Hirafu stations opened on the very same day, giving the mountain two railheads within a few kilometers of each other. In 1910 the government placed the seat of the newly formed Shiribeshi Subprefecture at Kutchan, and the settlement became a fully fledged town in 1916; further schools, including a junior high school, followed in 1922. A light railway to Kyogoku, opened in 1919 to move produce and passengers, would itself become a period piece: the national government closed it in 1986, the same year Kutchan hosted a national athletics meet under the nickname "Ezofuji Kutchan." Agriculture, not tourism, defined the town for most of the twentieth century: its first "Industrial Tourism Festival," held in 1963, later became the potato festival the town still runs today, and a potato mascot born for its 1991 centenary still represents it.²⁵

A Farm Given Away

A few kilometers away, in what was then Kaributo village, a very different kind of estate was taking shape. The novelist Arishima Takeo's father applied in 1898 for land in the Makaributo wilderness, and the farm his family built there grew until, in 1922, the year before his death, Arishima Takeo announced he was giving it to his tenant farmers outright, to be held in common rather than worked as rented land — an almost unheard-of act among Japanese landowners of the period. A mutual-aid credit union set up to run the shared farm in 1924 carried his idea forward for a generation.⁶

The postwar land reform of 1949 finally converted the shared farm into private smallholdings, closing that chapter formally, and a memorial hall that admirers had built at the old farm office later burned down by accident in 1957. Reconstruction efforts begun in 1963 eventually led the town itself to build a proper museum on the same ground for the centenary of Arishima's birth; it opened in 1978 and stands there today — in Niseko-cho, Kutchan's neighbor, not in Kutchan itself, a reminder that the district's ski slopes and its most famous piece of land reform belong to two different, adjoining towns.⁶

Lieutenant-Colonel Lerch's Mountain

Modern skiing arrived in Japan only in January 1911, at Takada in Niigata, under the Austro-Hungarian military attaché Theodor von Lerch. Kutchan's own historical record places Lerch's party on Mount Yotei within about a year of that: it dates public ski demonstrations to 16 April 1912 and an attempt on the mountain the next day, recording that the party skied to the fourth station and walked to the summit from there. A 1924 Railway Ministry guidebook tells a different story, dating Lerch's only attempt to March of the following year and stating plainly that he did not reach the top, crediting the first summit instead to members of Hokkaido Imperial University's ski club in 1919, climbing with crampons. The two accounts agree only that Lerch came to the mountain around 1912-13; which climb, if either, actually reached the summit first is not something this dossier can resolve from the sources read.¹²

By 1924 the same guidebook could already send readers straight to Hirafu for the climb: a fare table lists third-class tickets from Otaru, Sapporo and Hakodate to Hirafu Station, and describes the recommended route up the mountain's western face — an eight-cho walk from the station into the town, then along the Sapporo highway to a climbing office at the trailhead, where the road coming down from Kutchan joined the same path, and from there some two ri (about eight kilometers) to the summit. The guide recommends this western, Hirafu-side approach precisely because it has "almost no cliffs and almost no avalanches," making for a satisfying climb with relatively little exertion, and it names Hirafu, Kutchan and three neighboring settlements as already "good places to ski."¹

From Kaributo to Niseko

Kaributo's own name outlived its usefulness once tourism arrived. In July 1963 the mountains above the village were designated part of the Niseko-Shakotan-Otaru Coast Quasi-National Park, and visitors and officials alike began complaining that a park called "Niseko" had no obvious front door, since the town beneath it was still called Kaributo. The town assembly first debated renaming only the railway station; from February 1964 an advisory meeting of council members pushed the idea forward, and on 24 April 1964 the assembly formally proposed changing both the station's name and the town's own name to Niseko. When it put the station question to Japanese National Railways, the railway refused that part outright the following month, citing a standing rule against place names written entirely in katakana.⁷

So the town changed its own name instead, over the objections of its neighbor: in August 1964 the mayors of four surrounding towns had to mediate a formal protest from Kutchan before Kaributo could proceed. On 1 October 1964 the town became Niseko-cho, only the second Japanese municipality ever to take an all-katakana name. The station followed years later, renamed Niseko on 1 April 1968 — the first station on the national railway to carry an all-katakana name of its own.⁷

Powder, Condominiums and a Declaration

The Alps reached Kutchan before the Australians did, at least on paper: in February 1964, while inspecting the Winter Olympics in Switzerland, Kutchan's mayor proposed a sister-city tie with St Moritz, formalised later that year. Kutchan formally declared itself a "town of skiing" in December 1972, and it was Australian visitors, arriving for the same dry powder snow the 1924 guidebook had already praised, who eventually turned that identity into an industry: by the town's own account, Australian-led condominium development in the resort area took off from the late 2000s, after resort-area land prices had already begun climbing from the mid-2000s. The town's overnight stays by foreign visitors rose to about 460,000 in the 2018 financial year, 2.8 times the 2009 figure, even as total visitor numbers recovered from a mid-1990s slump to about 1.65 million that same year.⁴

The 2008 financial crisis and the 2011 earthquake briefly slowed construction, but investment resumed from the mid-2010s, increasingly from other parts of Asia as well as Australia, with one company typically developing an entire self-contained resort — hotels, condominiums, lifts and shops together — rather than single buildings, alongside a separate boom in staff housing in Kutchan's own town center as the resort's workforce grew. By January, the month when the resident foreign population peaks, more than one in seven residents registered in the town is a foreign national. In October 2019 the G20 tourism ministers met at the Niseko Hanazono resort, within Kutchan, and issued the "Hokkaido Kutchan Declaration" on sustainable tourism, formally recognizing a district that the town's own planners still describe as selling, above everything else, one "killer content": powder snow.⁴

Reading the Ground Today

Hirafu Station still stands where it opened in 1904, and the road it once sent climbers along toward Mount Yotei's climbing office is, in its essentials, the same route described in the 1924 guidebook. The Hirafu Shrine still marks the town's contested claim on Abe no Hirafu's name. What has changed is the scale: a settlement that Kutchan's own history remembers as raw forest cleared tree by tree in 1892, and that needed a mediated peace with its neighbor before that neighbor could even change its name in 1964, now draws close to half a million foreign guest-nights a year to the same mountainside, with a Shinkansen extension due to bring Kutchan a new station of its own within the decade.¹⁴⁵

It is worth remembering, walking or driving between the two, that "Niseko" as international visitors use the word today covers ground that Japanese administration still keeps carefully apart: the ski slopes above Hirafu, the station and the town hall belong to Kutchan, which fought in 1964 to keep its own name and identity distinct from its neighbor's; the Arishima farm, the 1964 renaming itself and the Niseko brand's own legal home belong to the separate town of Niseko-cho next door. The mountain the two towns share, and the marketing name that now covers both, sit on top of a boundary each town spent much of the twentieth century insisting on.⁶⁷

Timeline

658 CE (tradition)	The Nihon Shoki records Abe no Hirafu's fleet reaching "Koho Yotei"; local tradition, contested, ties this to the mountain and to Hirafu's name. ⁸
19 May 1892	The first settlers enter the Kutchan wilderness and begin clearing forest; the town's own accounts differently credit Manabe Hamasaburo (leading the entering party) and Niki Takekichi (organizing the effort). ²⁵
1893	Kutchan is registered as a village; Shirani Takeshi chooses the characters 倶知安 for its name. ³⁵
1898	Arishima Takeo's father applies for land in the Makaributo wilderness, in what is now Niseko-cho. ⁶
1901	Kaributo village separates from Makkari village, taking its name from "Makaributo." ⁷
15 Oct. 1904	The Hokkaido Railway opens; Kutchan and Hirafu stations open the same day. ²
1910	Shiribeshi Subprefecture's office opens at Kutchan. ⁵
April 1912 / March 1913	Lt.-Col. Theodor von Lerch's party attempts Mount Yotei on skis; Kutchan's own record says the party reached the summit on foot after skiing partway up, a 1924 guidebook says he did not reach it at all — sources disagree on both the year and the outcome. ¹²
1916	Kutchan attains full town status. ⁵
1919	Hokkaido Imperial University's ski club reaches the summit of Mount Yotei with crampons; a 1924 guidebook calls this the first successful ascent, though Kutchan's own record describes an earlier, 1912 summit by Lerch's party. ¹
1922	Arishima Takeo gives his Kaributo farm to his tenant farmers, to be held in common. ⁶
1 Oct. 1964	Kaributo becomes Niseko-cho, Japan's second all-katakana municipality name, after a dispute with Kutchan. ⁷
1 Apr. 1968	Kaributo Station is renamed Niseko Station, the first all-katakana station name on the national railway. ⁷
Dec. 1972	Kutchan declares itself a "town of skiing." ⁵

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1 Hirafu Station** 比羅夫駅. Open since 1904 on the Hakodate Main Line; a 1924 guidebook already sent skiers here for Mount Yotei, and it remains a gateway to the same slopes.¹²
- 2 Mount Yotei climbing trailhead, Hirafu (Kutchan) course** 羊蹄山登山道倶知安コース登山口. The western approach a 1924 guidebook described walking to from Hirafu Station; still the standard route up the mountain's Kutchan side today.¹
- 3 Hirafu Shrine** 比羅夫神社. Built in 1912 to mark the local tradition connecting the district to the seventh-century general Abe no Hirafu, a claim also made by other towns.⁸
- 4 Niseko Annupuri's Kutchan-facing slopes** ニセコアンヌプリ倶知安側斜面. Part of the ski terrain that let Kutchan declare itself a "town of skiing" in 1972 and that now anchors its international resort industry.⁴⁵
- 5 Kutchan townscape and former Shiribeshi Subprefecture seat** 倶知安市街・旧後志支庁所在地. The administrative and market town that grew from the 1892 settlement, seat of the Shiribeshi region's government from 1910 and now home to a large foreign-resident population.⁵

The same ground, 1974–1978 and 2025



1974–1978 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *gazo1*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2025 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2025*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

■ Volcanic terrain (eroded) 74%

■ Volcanic foot slopes 26%

GSI has no detailed landform survey for this frame, so the map uses GSI's regional classification (compiled for zoom levels 9–13). It shows the broad landform only; former river channels and man-made ground are not mapped at that scale.

What the main landforms mean

Volcanic terrain (eroded) (74%). Older volcanic slopes worn down so that only the broad form remains. Watch for slope disasters.

Volcanic foot slopes (26%). Gentle slopes built from volcanic ejecta and sediment carried down from a volcano. Eruptions and slope disasters.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.

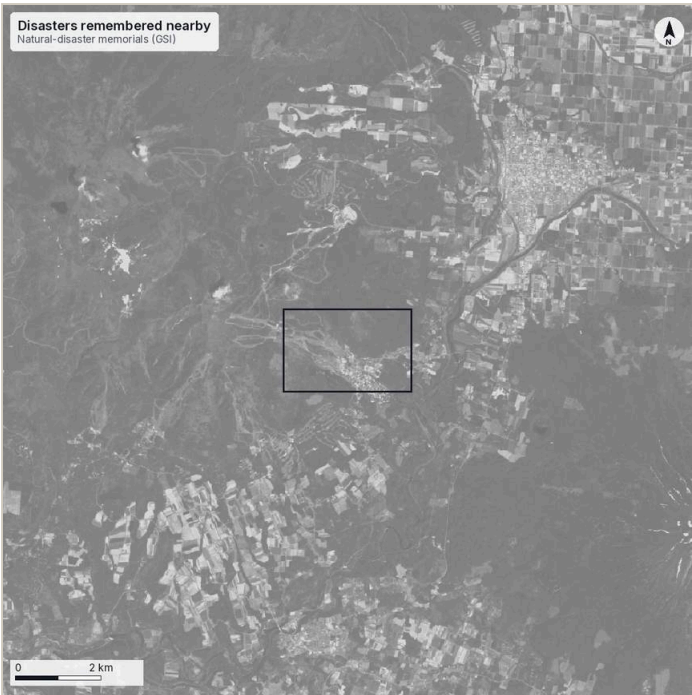
Man-made ground

No man-made ground mapped in this frame.

Meiji-era lowland

GSI has not traced Meiji-era lowland for this frame.

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.
Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
No memorial is registered within 30 km.			

What the memorials record

English notes for these memorials are being prepared.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 鉄道省 (Railway Ministry), スキーとスケート [Skiing and Skating], 1924; NDL frames 62, 63, 64, 65.
<https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1869439/1/62> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The Ezo-Fuji nickname and its cone shape; fares and the climbing route to Mount Yotei from Hirafu Station; Lerch's ski attempt and Hokkaido Imperial University's 1919 summit; Hirafu, Kutchan and neighboring places named as ski destinations.
2. 倶知安の歴史 (年表) [History of Kutchan (timeline)], 倶知安町 (Kutchan Town). <https://www.town.kutchan.hokkaido.jp/culture-sports/kucchan-history/history-nenpyou/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The town's own dated timeline: 1892 settlement, 1893 village, 1896 town-village system, 1904 railway, 1912 Lerch visit, 1916 town status, 1919 light railway, 1972 "town of skiing" declaration.
3. 町の概要 [Town profile], 倶知安町 (Kutchan Town). <https://www.town.kutchan.hokkaido.jp/profile/gaiyou/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The town's own account of its Ainu-derived name and the 1893 choice of the characters 倶知安 by the official Shirani Takeshi.
4. 倶知安町観光振興計画 2020-2031 [Kutchan Town Tourism Promotion Plan 2020-2031], 倶知安町 (Kutchan Town), 2020.
https://niseko.co.jp/wp/wp-content/uploads/2025/02/2020-2031_Kutchan_Town_Tourism_Promotion_Plan.pdf, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Visitor and foreign-guest-night trends 1990-2018; Australian-led development from the late 2000s and its slowdown; the shift toward Asian investment from the mid-2010s; the January foreign-resident share; the 2019 G20 tourism ministers' meeting and Hokkaido Kutchan Declaration.
5. 倶知安が歩んだ130年 (広報くっちゃん特集) [Kutchan's 130 years (town newsletter feature)], 倶知安町 (Kutchan Town).
<https://www.town.kutchan.hokkaido.jp/file/contents/4150/48619/21094-7.pdf>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Niki Takekichi's leadership of the 1892 settlers; the 1895 branch office and 1896 school; the 1904 railway; the 1910 Shiribeshi Subprefecture office; the 1912 Lerch visit; the 1916 town status; the 1972 ski-town declaration.
6. 有島武郎について／有島記念館概要 [About Arishima Takeo / outline of the Arishima Memorial Museum], 有島記念館, ニセコ町 (Arishima Memorial Museum, Niseko Town). https://www.town.niseko.lg.jp/arishima_museum/outline?wovn=en, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Arishima Takeo's father's 1898 land application in the Makaributo wilderness, the 1922 gift of the farm to tenant farmers, the 1924 cooperative, the 1949 land reform, the 1957 fire and the 1978 museum.
7. 狩太町はなぜニセコ町になったのかー全国2番目のカタカナ町名誕生の経緯 [Why Kaributo Town became Niseko Town: how Japan's second all-katakana town name came about], hokkaidofan.com. <https://hokkaidofan.com/kaributo-niseko/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1901 founding of Kaributo village; the 1963 national park designation; the 1964 station-renaming dispute, Kutchan's objection, and the town's renaming; the 1968 station renaming.
8. 阿倍比羅夫伝説の残るニセコ [Niseko, where the legend of Abe no Hirafu survives], hokkaido-travel.com (北海道Style).
<https://hokkaido-travel.com/unknown-hokkaido/abenohirafu/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The Nihon Shoki's account of Abe no Hirafu's 658 CE expedition and "Koho Yotei"; the 1912 Hirafu Shrine; the scholarly debate over which town, if any, the general reached.

Further reading

- 有珠虻田史 (大内古城 編, 1911) — The district's own early general history, covering Abuta-gun including the Kutchan and Kaributo settlements; listed as open online, but its NDL Lab record returned a server error on every attempt in this session and so was not read.
<https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763021> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 胆振要覧 (野沢嘉郎・倉田喜橘 著, 1908) — An overview of Iburi Province, the old administrative grouping that included Abuta-gun before the Shiribeshi Subprefecture was formed; its full-text search shows hits on "Kaributo," but its NDL Lab record also returned a server error in this session. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763017> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 移住手引北海之友：附・樺太案内 (堀田量 編, 1908) — A settlers' guide to Hokkaido with a hit on "Kaributo"; not readable in this session for the same server-error reason. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/763168> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 新篇倶知安町史 (倶知安町, 1990s-2000s) — The town's own modern official history, likely to hold far more detail on the Meiji settlement period, the Ainu-era background and the ski industry's growth than could be assembled here.
<https://ndlsearch.ndl.go.jp/search?cs=bib&keyword=%E5%80%B6%E7%9F%A5%E5%AE%89%E7%94%BA%E5%8F%B2> (print only)

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Detailed, verified records of the 1892-1916 settlement period (individual settler households, crop failures, the exact course of the 1895-1916 administrative changes)** — Kutchan Town's own archives and the Hokkaido Prefectural Archives (北海道立文書館). Contact the town's culture and history section directly, and search the prefectural archive's catalogue for Abuta-gun and Kutchan-mura records.
- **A full, primary-source resolution of the Lerch ski-ascent date discrepancy (April 1912 versus March 1913) and of the exact 1919 summit route** — Hokkaido University's Archives (北海道大学大学文書館), which holds early ski-club records, and contemporary newspaper morgues (北海道タイムス, 小樽新聞). Request the university archive's ski-club materials and search digitised newspaper collections for the relevant winters.
- **Primary correspondence and land records for the Arishima farm's 1922 transfer and the 1924 cooperative's operation** — The Arishima Memorial Museum's own collection and Niseko Town's archives. Contact the museum directly; it is likely to hold Arishima family papers and farm records beyond what its public-facing history page describes.

- **A ground-level account of the 1963-64 Kaributo/Niseko renaming dispute from the Kutchan side** — Kutchan Town's own council minutes and local newspaper coverage from 1963-64. Request the town assembly's historical minutes and check Hokkaido Shimbun's archive for the relevant months.
- **Systematic data on foreign land and condominium ownership in Hirafu since the 2000s, by nationality and year** — Kutchan Town's planning and taxation offices, and Ministry of Land, Infrastructure, Transport and Tourism land-price surveys. Request aggregated (non-personal) ownership statistics from the town office; consult the ministry's published chika chosa (land price survey) time series for the Kutchan-Hirafu area.

Caveats

- Several internet-accessible NDL items likely to hold the district's fullest early history — a 1911 Usu-Abuta history and a 1908 Iburi-province overview among them — returned server errors from the NDL Lab API on every attempt in this session and so are not cited as sources here, only listed in furtherReading. As a result this dossier rests on one NDL source rather than the four or more usually sought; readers wanting deeper pre-1920 local detail should treat this as a starting point.
- Sources disagree on both the year and the outcome of Lt.-Col. Lerch's Mount Yotei ski attempt: Kutchan's own timeline dates it to 17 April 1912 and states the party reached the summit on foot after skiing to the fourth station; a 1924 Railway Ministry guidebook dates Lerch's attempt to March 1913, says he did not reach the top, and credits the first summit instead to Hokkaido Imperial University's ski club in 1919. This dossier presents both accounts rather than resolving which, if either, is correct.
- The tradition connecting Hirafu and Mount Yotei's name to the seventh-century general Abe no Hirafu is reported here as local tradition, not settled history; the sources used are explicit that which, if any, present-day town his expedition reached is disputed, and that Yoichi makes a competing claim.
- This dossier could not independently confirm a specific recent figure for Australian guest-nights in Kutchan (a figure near 167,000-168,000 appears in town planning material); it cites instead the town's own 2018 total-foreign-guest-night figure (about 460,000), which was directly verifiable in a document opened in this session.

Digitised books are cited, not reproduced: the page frames let you open the same page in the NDL Digital Collections. Aerial photographs, landform and memorial data: GSI, processed by Japan Time Atlas. This experimental edition was checked against its cited sources on 2026-09-28 but has not had independent fact-checking.